Virtus the Veiled — Mono-Black Deathtouch Drain

Play guide · built 2026-10-21 · 100 cards, 36 lands · Bracket 3, 2 of 3 Game Changers (Demonic Tutor, Vampiric Tutor)

The commander

> ***Virtus the Veiled*** *— {2}{B} — Legendary Creature — Azra Assassin —* ***1/1***
> *Partner with Gorm the Great · Deathtouch*
> *Whenever Virtus deals combat damage to a player,* ***that player loses half their life, rounded up.***

He is a **1/1**. The half-life trigger does not care how much damage he deals, only that he connects. **Never spend a card pumping him.** Every resource goes into making him unblockable and keeping him alive. Two connections put almost anyone in burn range; from 40 that is 40 → 20 → 10.

Gorm the Great is not in the deck, so the Partner line does nothing. Ignore it.

What the deck actually does

It is not a creature deck that happens to drain. It is a **drain engine** with 26 deathtouch bodies acting as both defence and triggers. Three overlapping plans:

1. **Combo.** A two-card loop that kills the whole table at once. See the next page.
2. **Commander damage by halves.** Virtus or Quietus Spike connecting, repeatedly.
3. **Big black finishers.** Torment of Hailfire for a large X, Exsanguinate, or Gray Merchant of Asphodel off a high devotion count.

The kill — the 2×2 grid

Any card from the left column plus any card from the top row is an **infinite loop** that drains every opponent to zero. Four two-card combinations, which is why it assembles so often.

	Vito, Thorn of the Dusk Rose **Whenever you gain life, target opponent loses that much life**	**Marauding Blight-Priest** **Whenever you gain life, each opponent loses 1 life**
Exquisite Blood Whenever an opponent loses life, you gain that much life	Infinite — kills one opponent at a time	Infinite — kills the whole table
Bloodthirsty Conqueror Whenever an opponent loses life, you gain that much life (5/5 flier, deathtouch)	Infinite — kills one opponent at a time	Infinite — kills the whole table

The loop does NOT self-start

Both halves on the battlefield do nothing by themselves. You need **one life-change event** to spark it, and then it runs on its own. This is the single most important thing to know about the deck.

- **Extort** off Crypt Ghast — pay {W/B} on any spell. One mana, the cheapest spark.
- Any lifelink creature connecting.
- A fetch-style life payment, Read the Bones, Night's Whisper, Grim Tutor, Vampiric Tutor.
- **The Darkness Crystal** — any nontoken creature an opponent controls dying gains you 2.
- **An opponent attacking another opponent.** Any life loss at the table counts.

> ***Logged 2026-10-21:*** *the loop fired on an opponent's turn, when Collin attacked Douglas with Avacyn for 10. Conqueror gained 10, Blight-Priest drained, and the table died over roughly 38 iterations. The deck did nothing on the turn it won. Final life total 87.*

Evasion — the only thing Virtus needs

Card	What it does for Virtus	Cost
Commander's Plate	+3/+3 and **protection from white, blue, red and green** — every colour not in your identity. Unblockable by any non-black creature, and untargetable by four colours of removal.	{1}, equip commander {3}
Rogue's Passage	Unconditionally unblockable. Works against black decks, which the Plate does not.	{4}, {T}
Dauthi Embrace	Shadow — effectively unblockable, and repeatable on any creature.	{B}{B} per activation
Quietus Spike	A second copy of the half-life trigger that can ride a creature they are less afraid of.	{3}, equip {3}

Protection is DEBT — what it actually stops

Protection from a colour stops four things from sources of that colour: **D**amage, **E**nchanting/Equipping, **B**locking, and **T**argeting. It does **not** stop sacrifice effects, -X/-X, board wipes that say "destroy all", or exile that does not target. Commander's Plate is colourless, so it can still equip a creature it protects.

Black opponents are the hole

The Plate gives no protection from black and black creatures can block through it. Against a black deck, Rogue's Passage or Dauthi Embrace is the answer, not the Plate.

Deathtouch payoffs — read the trigger condition carefully

Card	Triggers on	Needs to connect?
Hooded Blightfang	A deathtouch creature you control **ATTACKS**	**No.** Fires on declaring attackers. Blocking it does not stop the drain.
White Widow, Yelena Belova	Deathtouch creature deals combat damage to a player	Yes
Black Widow, Deadly Hunter	Deathtouch creature deals combat damage to a player	Yes
Arnyn, Deathbloom Botanist	A creature you control with power **or** toughness 1 or less dies	No — it wants your small bodies to trade
Virtus / Quietus Spike	Combat damage to a player	Yes

The Blightfang line is the one that gets misplayed. Attacking with three small deathtouchers drains each opponent for 3 and gains you 3 *before blockers are even declared* — and that lifegain is a combo spark. Attack with everything even into a wall of blockers.

Why the one-mana bodies are in the deck

Hired Poisoner is a vanilla 1/1 deathtoucher and looks like filler. In the logged game it attacked twice and generated **six life of swing** through Blightfang while never dealing more than 1 damage. 26 of 31 creatures have deathtouch; the cheap ones are the engine's fuel, not padding.

The pinger lock

Viridian Longbow + **Thornbite Staff** on one deathtouch creature is repeatable removal: tap the Longbow ability to ping for 1, deathtouch destroys the target, the creature dying untaps your creature via Thornbite, repeat. It keeps going for as long as things keep dying. Add **Basilisk Collar** for lifelink and every kill is also a combo spark.

Mana — 29 Snow-Covered Swamps and why

Every basic in the deck is a **Snow-Covered Swamp**. Its type line is "Basic Snow Land — Swamp", so it is still a Swamp for every card that checks, including Cabal Stronghold's "basic Swamp".

Card	Scales off
Cabal Coffers	{2}, {T}: Add {B} for each **Swamp** you control
Cabal Stronghold	{3}, {T}: Add {B} for each **basic Swamp** you control
Crypt Ghast / **Nirkana Revenant**	Whenever you tap a Swamp for mana, add an additional {B} — these stack with each other
Nykthos, Shrine to Nyx	Your devotion to black (77 black pips in the deck)
Urborg, Tomb of Yawgmoth	Makes every land a Swamp, so all of the above count them
Deserted Temple	Untaps Cabal Coffers for a second activation

Extraplanar Lens — imprint on a Snow-Covered Swamp

> *Imprint — When this artifact enters, you may exile target land you control.*
> *Whenever a land with **the same name** as the exiled card is tapped for mana, **its controller** adds one mana of any type that land produced.*

Because your basics are snow, the name it matches is "Snow-Covered Swamp" — which nobody else is running. Imprint it on a plain Swamp by mistake and you double every opponent's Swamps too. **The imprinted land is exiled permanently.**

Liliana of the Dark Realms

Enters at **3 loyalty**, so the −3 kills her the turn you use it. The +1 fetches a **Swamp**, which makes Coffers, Stronghold, Nirkana and Crypt Ghast all better — it is not generic ramp. The −6 emblem gives every Swamp "{T}: Add {B}{B}{B}{B}": ten lands becomes forty mana, which is Torment of Hailfire for X=38. It needs three full turn cycles undefended. **Kaya's Ghostform enchants a creature OR a planeswalker** and is the only protection in the deck for her.

Misplays to avoid

- **Pumping Virtus.** He is a 1/1 and the trigger is half their life regardless. Spend on evasion instead.
- **Forgetting Blightfang fires on attack.** Attack with every deathtoucher even into blockers — the drain and the lifegain happen before blocks.
- **Holding the combo waiting for a "safe" turn.** The loop needs a spark, and sparks come from the whole table. Deploy both halves and let someone else start it.
- **Imprinting Extraplanar Lens on a non-snow land.** That hands the doubling to any opponent running Swamps.
- **Taking the command zone when Virtus dies while enchanted by Kaya's Ghostform.** The replacement is a choice — decline it, let him hit the graveyard, and Ghostform returns him with no commander tax.
- **Using Liliana's −3 as removal early.** It kills her. Only do it if the board demands it or you have already given up on the emblem.
- **Blocking with a deathtoucher and then sacrificing it before damage.** Blocked stays blocked (CR 509.1h) — the attacker deals no damage, but you also deal none, so the deathtouch is wasted unless you needed the body elsewhere.

Opening hand — what to keep

Keep anything with **three lands and a one- or two-drop deathtoucher**. The deck is 36 lands with heavy ritual support (Dark Ritual, Cabal Ritual, Culling the Weak, Bubbling Muck), so two-landers with a ritual and a tutor are keepable. Mulligan hands with no black source by turn two or with three cards costing five-plus.

Tutor priority early: a mana engine (Cabal Coffers or Crypt Ghast) beats a combo half. You find combo pieces faster off a big mana turn than off a turn-three Vito.

Reference numbers

Deck size	100 — 36 lands (29 Snow-Covered Swamp + 7 nonbasic), 64 spells
Creatures	31, of which **26 have deathtouch**
Black pips	77 — relevant for Nykthos and Gray Merchant of Asphodel
Game Changers	2 of 3 — Demonic Tutor, Vampiric Tutor. One slot free for Bracket 3.
Removal	3 dedicated (Go for the Throat, Snuff Out, Feed the Swarm), plus Witch of the Moors, The Darkness Crystal and the Longbow lock
Tutors	5 — Demonic Tutor, Vampiric Tutor, Grim Tutor, Diabolic Intent, Sidisi

Cards whose text people get wrong

- **Snow-Covered Swamp** is a Swamp. Everything that says Swamp, including "basic Swamp", reads it normally.
- **Extort** triggers once per spell you cast, and you may pay once per trigger. Two extort creatures means two separate triggers on the same spell.
- **Gray Merchant of Asphodel** counts **devotion**, which is black mana symbols on permanents you control — not cards, not Swamps.
- **The Darkness Crystal** replaces an opponent's nontoken creature dying with exile and **gains you 2 life**. That is a combo spark every time one of their creatures dies, and it shuts off their recursion.
- **Witch of the Moors** checks at your end step whether you gained life *that turn*. Any extort payment or lifelink hit turns it on.
- **Torment of Hailfire** gives each opponent the choice each iteration. Against a board full of permanents a small X does very little; it is a finisher, not a value spell.

Built from decks/deathtouch_reference.md. Every card's oracle text re-read from scryfall.db on 2026-10-21.